

## The Theban Saga



I see the ancient woes of the dead falling on the family of Labdacus, woe upon woe. No generation liberates the next, but some god shatters it. There is no release.

—SOPHOCLES, *Antigone* 594–598

### The Founding of Thebes

The historical Thebes was the leading city of Boeotia, the plainland area of central Greece, ringed by the mountain ranges of Parnes, Cithaeron, Helicon, and Parnassus and bounded on the east by the Straits of Euboea. Thebes was situated on the low ridge that separates the two chief plains of Boeotia; its citadel was called the Cadmeia, preserving the name of Cadmus, legendary founder of the city. Cadmus was son of Agenor, king of Tyre, and brother of Europa. Agenor sent him to find Europa, whose abduction from Tyre is one of several myths in which a woman was taken against her will from Asia to Europe or vice versa. Herodotus narrates these legends at the beginning of his *History* in order to underline the difference between mythology and history. In these myths the opposition of the Greek and Asiatic worlds, which came to a historical climax in the Persian Wars of 494–479 B.C., began when Phoenician traders kidnapped the Argive princess Io and took her to Egypt. The Greeks (whom Herodotus calls “Cretans”) in return seized the Phoenician princess Europa and took her to Crete. The pattern was then reversed: the Greeks took Medea from Colchis, and in return the Trojan Alexander (Paris) took Helen from Sparta. Herodotus explained that the Persians, reasoning from these myths,

believed that Europe and Asia were permanently divided and hostile. As a historian, he was skeptical about these tales, for he could not vouch for their truth, whereas he could report things of which he had knowledge: “About these things I am not going to come and say that they happened in this way or in another, but the man who I myself know was the beginner of unjust works against the Greeks, this man I will point out and advance with my story. . . .” (1.5) So for the Greek historian of the Persian Wars the distinction between myth and history was evident.

## Europa

The story of Europa is the first in which the Asiatic figure makes her way to the Greek world. In the usual version of the myth (which is different from the skeptical account of Herodotus), Zeus, disguised as a bull, took Europa to Crete. Here is Ovid’s description of the abduction (*Metamorphoses* 2. 846–3. 2), which should be compared with the nearby illustrations.

Majesty and love are not well joined, nor do they sit well together. Abandoning the dignity of his royal office, the father and ruler of the gods took on the appearance of a bull, and as a beautiful animal shambled over the tender grass. Agenor’s daughter [Europa] wondered at the bull’s beauty, amazed that he did not threaten to attack, yet, gentle as he seemed, she at first was afraid to touch him. After a while she came up close and offered flowers to his white face. The young princess even dared to sit upon the bull’s back. Then the god little by little began to take his deceptive steps further from the dry land into the sea, then he went further and carried his prey across the central waters of the sea. At length he laid aside the disguise of the deceiving bull and revealed who he 10 was and reached the shores of Crete.

In Crete, Europa became the mother of Minos by Zeus.

## Cadmus, Founder of Thebes

Meanwhile Cadmus, Europa’s brother, set out to find her and came to Delphi, where he asked the oracle for advice. Apollo told him not to worry about Europa any more but to follow a certain cow until she lay down out of weariness and there to found a city. Cadmus found the cow in Phocis (the district of Greece in which Delphi is situated), and she led him to **Boeotia**, where he founded his city, **Cadmeia**, later called Thebes. As for the divinely sent cow, it was Cadmus’ duty to sacrifice her; to perform the ceremony, he needed water, which he sent his companions to draw from the nearby spring sacred to Ares. A serpent, a child of Ares, guarded the spring; it killed most of Cadmus’ men, and in return was itself killed by Cadmus. Ovid relates that Cadmus then heard a voice saying: “Why, son of Agenor, do you look at the dead serpent? You too will be looked at as a serpent.” Thus the final episode in the life of Cadmus was prophesied.

Athena, to whom Cadmus had been sacrificing the cow, now advised Cadmus to take the serpent’s teeth and sow them; from the ground sprang up armed men, who fought and killed each other until only five were left. From these five

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|-----------------------|-------------------------------|
| 1. Cadmus             | 6. Laius                      |
| 2. Pentheus           | 7. Oedipus (regency of Creon) |
| 3. Labdacus           | 8. Eteocles                   |
| 4. Lycus              | 9. Creon                      |
| 5. Zethus and Amphion | 10. Laodamas                  |

**Figure 17.1.** The Kings of Thebes. (According to Sophocles, Polydorus became king after Pentheus; see genealogy, p. 415.)

survivors, who were called **Spartoi** (i.e., sown men), descended the noble families of Thebes.

Euripides recounts Cadmus' achievement as follows (*Phoenissae* [*The Phoenician Women*] 639–675):

Tyrian Cadmus came to this land where the cow fell down on all fours, providing irrevocable fulfillment of the oracle by which god had ordained that he was to make his home amid the fertile plains—here where the beautiful stream of Dirce waters the rich and green fields. . . . In this place the bloodthirsty serpent of Ares kept his savage guard over the freshly flowing waters, looking far and wide with his swiftly darting glances. Cadmus came for sacrificial water and destroyed him, wielding a stone by the might of his arm and showering deadly blows upon the monster's head. At the bidding of Pallas Athena, he sowed its teeth in the bountiful ground; and in their place Earth sent up onto its surface the spectacle of armored men. Iron-willed Slaughter sent them back to Mother Earth; and she who had presented them to the bright breezes of the upper air was steeped in their blood. 10

Now Cadmus had to appease Ares for the death of the serpent; he therefore became his slave for a year (which was the equivalent of eight of our years). At the end of this time, he was freed and given **Harmonia**, daughter of Ares and Aphrodite, as his wife. The marriage was celebrated on the Cadmeia, and all the gods came as guests. Among the gifts for the bride were a robe and a necklace from her husband; the necklace was made by Hephaestus and given by him to Cadmus; it came to play an important part in the Theban saga. Cadmus and Harmonia had four daughters—Ino, Semele, Autonoë, and Agave—whose stories, with those of their husbands and sons, are told in Chapters 10 and 13.

Despite the misfortunes of their daughters, Cadmus and Harmonia reigned a long time, civilizing their people and introducing knowledge of writing. Eventually, they went away to northwest Greece, where Cadmus became king of the Illyrians; at the end of their lives, they both were turned into great harmless serpents (according to Euripides and Ovid; Apollodorus says that Zeus sent them to Elysium). They were worshiped by their descendants, and their departure from Cadmeia was not the outcome of any misdeed or grief, but a symbol of their change from mortal to heroic or divine status.



## The Families of Labdacus and Lycus

Cadmus' successor as king was his grandson Pentheus, son of Agave, whose misfortunes are dealt with in Chapter 13. After his death, a new dynasty was founded by Labdacus, possibly a grandson of Cadmus. He is said to have perished while pursuing the same policy as Pentheus, leaving as his successor an infant son, Laius. Lycus, a great-great-uncle of Laius, first assumed the regency and then made himself king, reigning for twenty years. He was the son of Chthonius, one of the five Spartoi, and his family has an important legend. His brother's daughter **Antiope** was loved by Zeus; while she was pregnant, she fled to Sicyon (a city in the northern Peloponnese) to escape from the anger of her father, Nycteus. In despair Nycteus killed himself, and his brother (Lycus) then attacked Sicyon and recovered Antiope.



**The Abduction of Chrysippus.** Apulian bell-krater by the Darius painter, ca. 340 B.C. This illustrates a scene (probably part of the messenger's speech) from Euripides' lost tragedy, *Chrysippus*. In the lower register, Laius drives off in his four-horse chariot with Chrysippus, who reaches out to his father, Pelops. Pelops is dressed in oriental clothing and vainly stretches out his right hand. On the left two naked men with spears (possibly Atrous and Thyestes) appear to be trying to stop the chariot. In the upper register four gods are seated: from the left, Pan, Apollo, Athena, and Aphrodite, who is approached by a winged Eros. To the right is the old tutor (Paidagogos) of Chrysippus. (Bildarchiv Preussischer Kulturbesitz/Art Resource, NY)

### Ovid and the Iconography of the Rape of Europa

*She is afraid, and as she is borne away she gazes back at the receding shore. She grasps a horn with her right hand; her left rests upon its back. Her billowing garments flutter in the breeze.*

METAMORPHOSES 2. 872–875

*She grabbed his mane with her right hand, and with her left her clothes. Her very fear was an added adornment.*

FASTI 5. 607–608

The iconography of the Rape of Europa has proven tenacious, from one of the earliest depictions of the story in the metope from Selinus, through Ovid's treatment of the tale in his *Metamorphoses* and *Fasti*, to the masterpiece created by Titian. Artistic representations both in antiquity and later typically isolate one of two moments in the story: either the scene of Europa among her companions as she approaches the bull and garlands its head with flowers, or of Europa on the back of the bull as it careers through the sea. In the metope, Europa, riding sidesaddle, grasps a horn with her left hand, which seems the obvious choice, since in most visual representations of the story in antiquity, the movement is

**The Rape of Europa.** Limestone metope from Selinus, ca. 540 B.C.; height 58 in. Europa rides over the sea, represented by the dolphins, upon the bull, which looks frontally at the viewer. The formality and restraint of the relief contrast with the swirling motion of Titian's painting. (Scala/Art Resource, NY)





generally from left to right. Europa appears rather calm as she steadies herself with a hand (her right) on the bull's back. The movement of the bull across the waters is suggested by the positioning of the forelegs and the dolphins beneath. The frontal gaze of the bull (characteristic of Greek Archaic art; see p. 545) is meant perhaps to suggest that the bull is not what it appears to be.

In Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, the positioning of the hands is reversed, but special attention is given to her garments and her alarm. Indeed, the motion of her clothes (*tremulae vestes*) mirrors her own movements, her gaze, and the state of her mind; she is gripped by a restless panic, the effect of which the poet enhances by focusing first on her being carried away and then on her looking back at a shore that is fast moving away from her. In the *Fasti*, Ovid has altered one detail: he now has one of her hands grab at her clothes, and the association of her fear with her garments is further underscored by describing her terror as an adornment.

Titian's treatment, one of a series of what he termed *poesie*, since they treated erotic myths selected from Ovid's *Metamorphoses*, was painted for Philip II of Spain. The composition reflects a number of features of both the metope and Ovid's description. The bull has launched himself into the sea and, as in the metope, gazes out at the viewer. The garland on its head alludes to the earlier incident onshore. The scene moves from left to right, one of Europa's hands (her left) grasps a horn, and, as in Ovid's *Fasti*, the other grasps her fluttering wrap. Her alarm, as in Ovid, is highlighted. The awkward diagonal movement across the canvas, which has brought the pair closer to the viewer; the distant shore, which appears so remote; and the contrast between Europa's gaze and the bull's wonderfully represent the tension of movement in Ovid's account (2. 872).



**The Rape of Europa**, by Titian (ca. 1487–1576); oil on canvas, 1559–1562; 73 x 81 in. Titian relies on Ovid's narratives (*Fasti* 5. 605–614 and *Metamorphoses* 2. 843–875). As in the Selinus metope, dolphins swim near the bull (one in the right foreground and one supporting a cupid), and Europa grasps the bull's horn. Her windblown drapery and desperate gestures, and the cupids flying through the air, impart an air of agitated movement in keeping with the mixed emotions, fear and anticipation, of the principal figures. In the distant background, Europa's companions vainly call her back to the shore. (Credit: *Europa*, 1559–62 (oil on canvas) by Titian [Tiziano Vecellio] [c.1488–1576] © Isabella Stewart Gardner Museum, Boston, MA, USA/ The Bridgeman Art Library Nationality/copyright status: Italian/out of copyright)

Somewhere in Boeotia, Antiope gave birth to twin sons, who were left to die. A shepherd found them and named them **Amphion** and **Zethus**. Zethus became a skilled herdsman, while Amphion became a musician, playing on a lyre given him by the god Hermes. Many years later, Amphion and Zethus met and recognized their mother, who had escaped from the imprisonment in which she was kept by Lycus and his wife, Dirce. They avenged Antiope by killing Lycus and tying Dirce to the horns of a bull that dragged her to her death. From Dirce's blood sprang the fountain at Thebes that is called by her name.

Amphion and Zethus now became rulers of Cadmeia and drove Laius into exile. They built walls for the city, whose stones were moved into place by the music of Amphion's lyre. Amphion married Niobe (whose story is told on p. 225), and Zethus married Thebe, in whose honor the newly walled city was renamed Thebes.

The story of the family of Lycus repeats motifs from the story of Cadmus. The walling of Cadmeia and its renaming is a doublet of the founding of the city by Cadmus, and just as Cadmus and Harmonia civilized their people, so Amphion's music demonstrated the power of harmony and beauty over the disunited and inanimate stones.

## Laius

After a reign of many years, Amphion and Zethus died, after which Laius returned from exile and resumed the kingship of which he had been deprived as an infant. In exile, he had been hospitably received by **Pelops**, king of Elis. The ties of guest and host were among the most sacred of human relationships, and Laius brought upon himself and his descendants a curse by abducting **Chrysippus**, the son of Pelops, with whom he had fallen in love. In his lost tragedy *Chrysippus*, Euripides made Laius "the first of the Hellenes to practice love for men," an accepted practice among Athenian men in Euripides' time. The scene in the Darius painter's vase shows the violence of Laius and the dismay of Pelops and Chrysippus, who committed suicide after the rape. Apollo foretold the working out of the curse in the first generation when Laius (now king of Thebes) consulted the Delphic oracle about the children who should be born to him and his wife, Jocasta. This is the reply of the oracle (Sophocles, *Argument to Oedipus Tyrannus*):

I will give you a son, but you are destined to die at his hands. This is the decision of Zeus, in answer to the bitter curses of Pelops, whose son you abducted; all this did Pelops call down upon you.

## Oedipus, Son of Laius and Jocasta

When a son was born, Laius attempted to avoid the fate foretold by the oracle by ordering the infant to be exposed upon **Mt. Cithaeron**, with a spike driven through his ankles. The servant entrusted with the task pitied the baby and instead gave him to a Corinthian shepherd (for the Theban and Corinthian summer pastures were adjacent on Cithaeron). The shepherd in turn brought the infant to his master, **Polybus**, king of Corinth. The child was brought up as the son of Polybus and his queen, **Merope**, and was called Oedipus (which means "swellfoot") from the injury to his ankles.



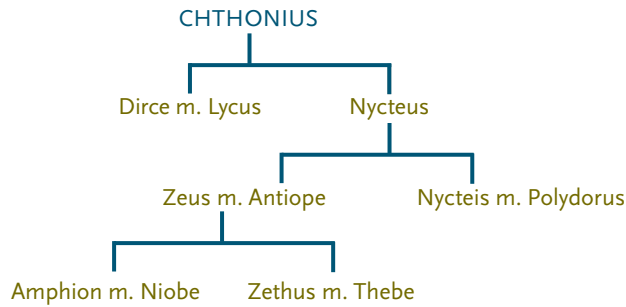


Figure 17.2. Descendants of Chthonius

Years later, a drunken companion jeered at Oedipus during a feast at Corinth and said that he was not Polybus' natural son. In alarm and shame at the taunt (which soon spread through the city), Oedipus left Corinth to ask the oracle at Delphi who his parents were. The oracle warned him in reply to avoid his homeland, since he must murder his father and marry his mother. So he determined not to return to Corinth and took the road from Delphi that led to Thebes. What happened then, Oedipus himself relates to Jocasta (Sophocles, *Oedipus Tyrannus* 800–813):

As I came on my journey to this junction of three roads, a herald and a man (like him whom you described) riding in a horse-drawn chariot blocked my way; they violently drove me off the road. In anger I struck the driver, who was pushing me



**Oedipus and the Sphinx.** Interior of Attic red-figure cup by the Oedipus painter, ca. 470 B.C. Oedipus, dressed as a traveler, ponders the riddle of the Sphinx, who sits on an Ionic column. The Sphinx is winged, with a woman's head and a lion's body and tail. (Vatican Museums)

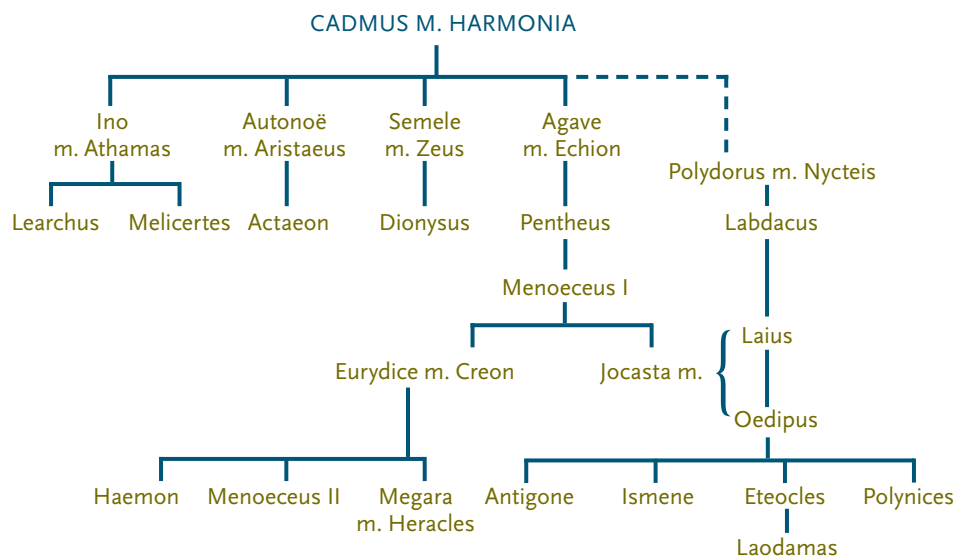


Figure 17.3. The Dynasties of Thebes





**Oedipus and the Sphinx**, by Gustave Moreau (1826–1898); oil on canvas, 1864, 81 ¼ x 4 ¼ in. The sphinx clutches Oedipus, ready to tear him in pieces (like his predecessors whose remains lie in the foreground), while Oedipus gazes at her intensely. Like Ingres (*Oedipus and the Sphinx*, 1808), Moreau sets the scene in the mountains outside Thebes (faintly seen in the background of both paintings), but he paints the whole of the monster's body and includes a column with a serpent, topped by an ancient vase with griffins' heads, copied from an engraving by Piranesi. The close physical contact of man and monster heightens the intensity of Oedipus' encounter. This was Moreau's best-known work, and it drew the attention of critics (favorable and unfavorable) and cartoonists (Daumier's caption read in part: "A bare-shouldered cat with the head of a woman, so that's called a sphinx?"). (Image copyright © The Metropolitan Museum of Art/Art Resource, NY)

aside; and when the old man saw me passing by him, he took aim at the middle of my head and struck me with the two-pronged goad. But he paid for this with interest; struck promptly by the staff in this hand of mine, he quickly tumbled out of the chariot. I killed them all.<sup>1</sup>

The old man, whom Oedipus did not recognize, was Laius. The curse of Pelops was being fulfilled.

## Oedipus and the Sphinx

So Oedipus came to Thebes, a city in distress; not only was the king dead, but also the city was plagued by a monster sent by Hera, called Sphinx (which means "strangler"). This creature had the face of a woman, the body of a lion, and the wings of a bird. It had learned a riddle from the Muses, which it asked the Thebans. Those who could not answer the riddle, it ate; and it was prophesied that Thebes would be free of the Sphinx only when the riddle was answered. The riddle was: "What is it that has one name that is four-footed, two-footed, and three-footed?"<sup>2</sup> No Theban had been able to find the answer; and in despair, the regent **Creon** (son of Menoeceus and brother of Jocasta) offered both the throne and his sister as wife to anyone who could do so. Oedipus succeeded. "Man," said he, "is the answer: for as an infant he goes upon four feet; in his prime upon

two; and in old age he takes a stick as a third foot." And so the Sphinx threw itself off the Theban acropolis; Oedipus became king of Thebes and husband of the widowed queen, his mother.

## The Recognition of Oedipus

Thus the prophecy of Apollo was fulfilled; what remained was for the truth to be discovered. There are three versions of Oedipus' fate, two Homeric and one Sophoclean. According to Homer, Epicasta (Homer's name for Jocasta) married her own



Closer Look

son, “and the gods speedily made it known to mortals. Unhappily, he reigned on at Thebes, but she went down to the house of Hades, fastening a noose to the roof of the lofty hall” (*Odyssey* 11. 271). In the *Iliad*, Oedipus is spoken of as having fallen in battle. In this version, another wife is the mother of the children of Oedipus.

The most widely accepted story, however, is the later version, that of Sophocles. Oedipus and Jocasta lived happily together, and she bore him two sons, **Polynices** and **Eteocles**, and two daughters, **Antigone** and **Ismene**. After many years, a plague afflicted Thebes, and the oracle of Apollo advised the Thebans that it was the result of a pollution on their state, for the murderer of Laius was in their midst. At this point, Polybus died, and the messenger who brought the news also brought the invitation to Oedipus from the people of Corinth to become their king. Oedipus, still thinking that Merope was his mother, refused to return to Corinth; but the messenger—who was the same shepherd to whom the infant exposed on Cithaeron had been given—tried to reassure him by telling him that he was not in fact the son of Merope and Polybus. Oedipus then sent for the servant to whom Laius had given his infant son to be exposed on Mt. Cithaeron. This man was also the sole survivor of the incident in which Laius died. Now the truth came out. This is how Sophocles describes the moment of Oedipus’ discovery. He is questioning the servant (who already knows the truth) in the presence of the messenger (*Oedipus Tyrannus* 1164–1185):

OEDIPUS: Which of these citizens [gave you the baby] and from what house [did it come]?

SERVANT: Do not, I beg you by the gods, master, do not question me any more. (1165)

OEDIPUS: You will be killed if I have to ask you this question again.

SERVANT: Well, it was one of the children of Laius.

OEDIPUS: A slave? Or one of his own children?

SERVANT: Alas! I am on the point of revealing a terrible secret!

OEDIPUS: And I of hearing it. Yet hear it I must. (1170)

SERVANT: Well, it was called the son of Laius. The woman inside the palace best would tell—your wife—the facts. 10

OEDIPUS: So she it was who gave you the baby?

SERVANT: Yes, my lord.

OEDIPUS: For what purpose?

SERVANT: That I might kill him.

OEDIPUS: Was she his mother, unhappy woman?

SERVANT: Yes, and she was afraid of the harm that had been foretold by the oracle. (1175)

OEDIPUS: And what was that?

SERVANT: The prophecy was that he would kill his parents. 20

OEDIPUS: How then did you give him up to this old man, how did you?

SERVANT: I was sorry for him, master, and I thought this man would carry him to another country, from which he came himself. But he saved him for evils much worse. For if *you* are the person this man says you are, then, I tell you, you were born to a wretched destiny. (1178–1181)

OEDIPUS: Alas! Alas! All is revealed! O light, may this be the last time I look upon you, I who have been shown to be born from those from whom I should not have been born, to be living with those with whom I should not live, and to have killed those whom I should not have killed! (1182–1185)



The horror of Oedipus' predicament is powerfully expressed in the stark dialogue, and it is no wonder that Sophocles' version of the myth has swept aside all other versions.<sup>3</sup> While Oedipus was questioning the servant, Jocasta, who already knew the truth, had gone into the palace and hanged herself. Oedipus rushed into the palace and, when he saw her corpse, blinded himself with the brooches from her robe. Creon became regent again, and Oedipus was banished, in accordance with a curse he himself earlier pronounced on the (as yet unknown) killer of Laius and in obedience to an oracle of Apollo.

## The End of the *Oedipus Tyrannus*

Modern readers and viewers of Sophocles' tragedy are likely to find the 234 lines (15 percent of the whole) that are spoken after the entry of the blind Oedipus an anticlimax after the discovery of his identity. This would be a mistake. Oedipus establishes the true measure of his heroic stature in his lament and dialogue with the Chorus and with Creon. The central themes of the tragedy are the relationship of the human to the divine and, as a consequence, the way in which human beings react to or control events brought about by the divine will. The audience knows the end result of Oedipus' search for the killer before he begins the process of discovery. Part of the suspense lies in our not knowing how he will react to the discovery. His self-blinding cannot be the end of the story: Sophocles shows how this act begins the next part of the hero's life, in which he proves his worth as a human being, accepting the will of the gods while still asserting his own dignity and independence. Thus he cries out to the Chorus (1329–1335):

Apollo it was, Apollo, who brought to fruition these my evil sufferings. No one struck [my eyes] but I in my misery. Why should I need to see, when there is nothing sweet for me to see?

Oedipus recognizes the power of the god and the impossibility of avoiding the divine will. Yet he also recognizes his own responsibility—he is the one who committed the crimes against the divine law, and he is the one who blinded himself. He is also the one who now, even in his miserable state, gives instructions to Creon (1446: “These are my orders to you. . . .”) for the burial of Jocasta, for his own exile from Thebes (where, he commands, he is not to be buried), and for the reunion with his daughters, Antigone and Ismene, who in the last lines of the play are taken from him as he is led back into the palace.

The nobility of Sophocles' interpretation can be seen if we look back to the lines in the tragedy where Jocasta dismisses the prophecies of Apollo, thinking that the details of the killing of Laius, as told by Oedipus, have proved that the oracle was false (857–858):

I would not in the future look for prophecies on this side or on that.

The Chorus, speaking for ordinary citizens of Thebes (or of any Greek city that honored the gods), is appalled. They (so they affirm) will not resist what is fated, for its laws have been established by Zeus and never die, while human beings grow old and die. The human being who dismisses the laws of Zeus commits

hubris (pride, leading to insolent violence) and becomes a tyrant, his world being one in which the proper order of things human and divine is thrown into disorder. Such insolence, so the Chorus sings, they never will display. In famous lines they conclude (893–896):

What man who lives his life like this [i.e., disregarding the divine law] can protect his soul from the shafts [of Zeus]? If deeds such as his are honored, why should I dance in the Chorus?

In the lines that follow these words, they pray to Zeus to assert his power, for if the prophecies of Apollo are disregarded, then religion (and with it, the power of the gods) no longer has any meaning.

Immediately after this chorus, in a brilliant dramatic stroke, Sophocles brings on Jocasta, the very person who had declared that the prophecies of Apollo were useless. She has kept faith in the god but not in the prophecies she believes were delivered by his false prophets. Jocasta sacrifices at the altar of Apollo but to no avail. In bitter irony, her prayer is answered at once by the arrival of the Corinthian messenger, who sets in motion events leading to her own death. The inexorable progress of Oedipus' discovery continues to its fated climax.

Returning now to the last scene of the tragedy, we see that the power of Zeus is confirmed, but with it comes the potential for the hero to assert his dignity in the face of the worst that the will of Zeus can do to him. In the final lines of the drama, the Chorus, in lines that appear repeatedly in Sophocles (and in Herodotus' story of Croesus, as told in Chapter 6), sing (1528–1530):

Call no man happy until he reaches the end of his life without suffering.

The will of Zeus, as foretold by Apollo at Delphi, has triumphed, but so also has Oedipus, who has asserted his greatness as a human being and has not given in to despair.

## Sophocles' *Oedipus at Colonus*

Sophocles died in 406–405 B.C. at about the age of ninety, and his final drama, *Oedipus at Colonus*, was produced at Athens by his grandson in 401.<sup>4</sup> It is the longest of Sophocles' tragedies, and it is a profound meditation on the wisdom that old age brings after a lifetime of experience—success and failure, suffering and happiness. It develops the themes of the *Oedipus Tyrannus*, produced in about 428, bringing the hero to his mysterious yet glorious end near the village of Colonus, the birthplace of Sophocles himself.

The drama begins with Oedipus, after years of wandering as an exile and beggar, coming to Colonus accompanied by Antigone. A citizen of Colonus tells him that he is on holy ground, sacred to the Eumenides, daughters of Earth and Darkness, ground possessed also by Poseidon and Prometheus. The citizen leaves to find the king of Athens, **Theseus**, and Oedipus prays to the Eumenides that they will bring an end both to his wandering and to his life, as prophesied by Apollo and hinted at in the dialogue with Creon at the end of the *Oedipus Tyrannus*. Thus, in this imposing opening scene, Sophocles sets out the essential plot of the drama, the climax of which is to be the end of the hero's life on earth.

A Chorus of old men, citizens of Colonus, enters and learns the identity of this stranger. Naturally, they think he is a pollution on their land, and in the subsequent scenes Oedipus looks back on his crimes from the perspective of the end of a long life. Thus he says (265–274):

Neither [the condition of] my body nor my deeds were mine. Know that I was the sufferer in my deeds, not the agent, if I *must* tell you of what happened with my mother and my father. This is why you are afraid of me, I know well. Yet how was I evil in nature if I reacted to what I suffered, so that, if I did what I did with full awareness, I would not have been an evil-doer? Yet, as it is, I have come where I have come not knowing what I did. I suffered and was destroyed by those who knew [i.e., the gods].

So in this play Sophocles discusses the intractable question of Oedipus' guilt or innocence more fully than in the earlier tragedy. By establishing the innocence of Oedipus, he prepares for his transformation to heroic status (in the religious sense) at the end of his life, while he in no way diminishes the horror that we (represented by the citizens of Colonus) feel at his crimes of parricide and incest. The role of the Eumenides in the drama makes Sophocles' solution yet more powerful, for they had been the Erinyes, the terrible goddesses who pursued and punished those who committed crimes against members of their own families.<sup>5</sup> It is in their sacred temenos (enclosure) that the action takes place, and it is to them that Oedipus first prays before the entry of the Chorus and again following the instructions of the Chorus (486–487):

Since we call them Eumenides you should pray that they should be the suppliant's saviors, acting with kindly hearts.

The action of the drama is therefore intertwined with the resolution of Oedipus' crimes, so that at the end he is justified and can control the final scene of his life, as he proceeds to his miraculous disappearance from the earth.

Creon, king of Thebes, appears with an armed escort and tries by persuasion and by force to get Oedipus to return to Thebes, even kidnapping Antigone and Ismene in his efforts to overpower him. But Oedipus is secure in the protection of Theseus, which the Athenian king has promised him before the appearance of Creon. Theseus appears just as the young women have been led off, and he sends soldiers to recover them. Meanwhile, Creon attempts to justify himself before Theseus, the Chorus, and Oedipus, whose great speech in response is the most detailed defense of his actions. We translate most of it here (962–1002):

Murder, marriage, misfortune—you have hurled these charges from your mouth. These things I suffered unwillingly, for they were the will of the gods, who perhaps have been angry with our family for generations past. As for myself alone, you never could reproach me for a crime in doing the deeds I did against myself and members of my family. Then show me this: if you came upon an oracle prophesying that [my] father must be killed by his children, how could you justly call me guilty? My mother had not then been filled with my father's seed, and I had not been conceived. Again, if I, appearing as the victim of an evil fate (as I did appear)—if I fought with my father and killed him, knowing nothing



of what I was doing and to whom I was doing it, how could you reasonably find 10  
fault with an unwilling deed? (962–977)

Then, you wretch, you are not ashamed to force me to speak of my mother's marriage, your own sister! I will speak, I will not be silent. . . . For she bore me—yes, she gave me birth, unhappy man that I am. She did not know, and I, her child, knew not. She gave birth to me and then to her shame bore children to me. One thing I know, that you slander her and me in saying that I did these things willingly. Unwillingly did I marry her, and unwillingly do I say these things now. Not even in this marriage can you find me guilty, nor in the murder of my father (which you constantly bring up with your bitter charges). Answer me this one question: if someone came up to you—you righteous man—to kill you, 20  
would you ask if your killer were your father? Or would you pay him back immediately? I think, if you love life, you would pay back the criminal and you would not look round for justification. (978–996)

Well, these were the evils that I walked into, led by the gods. I do not think even my father's soul, if he were alive again, would disagree. But you, you are not just: you think it good to say anything, things that can be spoken and things that should remain unspoken, and you make these charges in the presence of these men. (997–102)

Oedipus ends by calling on the Eumenides to support him and his protector, Theseus (1010–1013):

I call upon these goddesses, I beg them with my prayers, to come as my helpers and defenders, so that you [Creon] may know what sort of men are guardians of this city [Athens].

Creon leaves, and Theseus' soldiers return with Antigone and Ismene. But now another threat to Oedipus appears as Polynices, his elder son, comes from Argos to ask his father's blessing and presence as he marches with six heroic allies to claim the throne of Thebes. Before Polynices appears, Theseus promises Oedipus that he will not allow him to leave under compulsion, and we know therefore that Polynices will fail. The scene between Polynices and Oedipus is powerful. Though Oedipus is blind and a wandering beggar, he is still the father who has the authority to bless or curse his son.

Polynices makes a self-serving speech, in which he describes the expedition that he is making against his own city.<sup>6</sup> He knows that the army that has Oedipus with it will be victorious, and he promises to restore Oedipus to Thebes. Oedipus' reply is a masterpiece of reproach and chastisement. He shows who in fact has been guilty of transgressing the unwritten laws of the family, the very charge that he himself had answered in his speech to Creon. He says (1354–1364):

When you held the power and ruled at Thebes, as now your brother does, yourself you banished your own father; you made me a man without a city and made me wear these rags, which now make you weep to see. Now you suffer the same troubles as I and suffer the same evils. They do not call for tears, but I must endure them all my life, as I remember that you were my destroyer. You made me live with suffering, you thrust me out; you made me a wanderer who must beg his daily life from others.

Oedipus disowns his sons, contrasting them with Antigone and Ismene, who have truly been loyal to him. He foretells the failure of the expedition against Thebes, reminding Polynices that he had cursed him long ago. He curses him once more (1383–1396):

Go! I spit you out, you are no son of mine. You are the worst of evil men. Take with you these curses which I call down on you—never may you rule your own land by force, and never may you return to the vale of Argos. May you die by your brother's hand and may you kill the man [your brother] who drove you out! These are my curses. I call on the hateful, dark abyss of Tartarus, where my ancestors lie, to keep you from your city. I call on these goddesses [the Eumenides]; I call on Ares, who thrust this terrible hatred into your hearts. Hear this and go! Tell all the Thebans and tell your loyal allies that Oedipus has bequeathed this legacy to his children.

Before he goes, Polynices refuses to listen to Antigone's request that he give up his expedition. In Antigone's moving words Sophocles foreshadows her fate: to die upholding the unwritten laws of Zeus that compel her to break the laws of man in burying her brother. This is the plot of Sophocles' tragedy *Antigone*.

## The End of the Life of Oedipus

The drama of *Oedipus at Colonus* has looked back at Oedipus' crimes and has proved him innocent of deliberate intention in his crimes against his family. It has looked forward to the self-destructive hatred of the sons of Oedipus for each other, and it has foreshadowed the tragic self-sacrifice of Antigone. It has brought Oedipus to Colonus, where he is protected by the earthly power of King Theseus and the divine power of the Eumenides. One thing remains, the final moments of the hero's life on earth. As Polynices leaves, thunder is heard, and Oedipus knows that this is the sign for the ending of his life. Theseus reappears, and the blind Oedipus, with the authority of one who fully knows who he is and at peace with himself, leads him and the young women toward the place where his life will end. He blesses Theseus and Athens, asking only that Theseus never reveal the place of his disappearance.

What happens next is related in the speech of the messenger who was an eyewitness. We give the passage in full here, since it clearly tells us how Sophocles viewed the relationship of Oedipus the man to Oedipus the hero. The poet carefully describes the place, for a hero is associated with a particular locality. He connects Oedipus' passing with the powers beneath the earth (Zeus is called by his title Chthonius, that is, "Zeus of the Earth"); yet Theseus rightly worships the powers of both earth and heaven after the miracle, for the hero is part of the array of Greek divinities, those of heaven as well as the chthonic powers. And Oedipus' passing is miraculous and without grief, in this symbolizing his benign influence on the place where he passed from mortal sight and his power as a hero to perform miracles for those who worship him. Here then is Sophocles' description (*Oedipus at Colonus* 1587–1665):



You know how he left this place without any of his friends to guide him, himself the leader of us all. When he came to the edge of the ravine, which is rooted in the earth by the brazen stairs, he stood in one of the paths which meet there—the place is by the hollow basin where the pact of Theseus and Pirithoüs was forever made. Around him were the rock of Thoricus, the hollow wild pear tree, and the stone tomb. Here he sat and loosened his dust-stained garments. Then he called his daughters and bade them bring him water from the running stream to wash with and make libations. So they went to the hill of Demeter, bringer of green freshness, which overlooks the place, and soon returned bringing what their father had asked for. Thus they washed and clothed him as custom demands. When he was satisfied with all that they were doing and none of his commands had gone unfulfilled, then Zeus of the Earth thundered, and the girls shuddered as they heard. They clasped their father's knees and wept; continuously they beat their breasts and wailed. But he immediately answered their unhappy cry, clasped his arms around them, and said: "My children, today your father ceases to be. All that is mine has come to an end; no more need you labor to support me. Hard was that task, I know, my daughters; yet one word alone relieves all that toil—for of *Love* you never will have more from any man than me. And now you will pass your lives bereft of me." (1587–1619)

10

In this way, they all sobbed and wept, embracing each other. When they came to an end of weeping and were silent, a sudden voice called him and all were afraid and their hair stood on end. It was God who called him repeatedly. "Oedipus, Oedipus," he called, "why wait we to go? Too long have you delayed." Then Oedipus, knowing that God was calling him, called King Theseus to him, and when he drew near said: "Dear friend, give your hand to my children as a solemn pledge, and you, my children, give yours to him. And do you, Theseus, swear never knowingly to betray these girls and always to act for their good?" And Theseus, without complaint, swore on his oath that he would do as his friend asked, for he was a man of generous nature. (1620–1637)

20

When this was done, Oedipus straightway felt his children with unseeing hands and said: "My daughters, you must resolutely leave this place; you may not ask to see what is not right for you to see, nor hear words that you should not hear. Go then; let only King Theseus stay and behold what will be done." (1638–1644)

30

All of us heard his words, and with groans and tears went with the girls. As we began to leave, we turned and saw Oedipus no longer there; the king we saw, shielding his eyes with his hand, as if some dread sight had appeared which he could not bear to look upon. Yet soon after we saw him worship Earth and Olympus, the gods' home above, with the same words. (1645–1655)

How Oedipus died no man can tell except Theseus. No fiery thunderbolt from God consumed him, no whirlwind from the sea. Some divine messenger came for him, or the deep foundations of the earth parted to receive him, kindly and without pain. Without grief he passed from us, without the agony of sickness; his going was more than mortal, a miracle. (1656–1665)

40

So Oedipus became a hero, bringing good to the country in which he lay, and thus Sophocles honors Attica and his own deme of Colonus in this version of the end of Oedipus' life.



## Other Versions of the Myth of Oedipus

There were, however, other versions. We have seen (pp. 416–417) that in Homer Jocasta is not the mother of Oedipus' children and that he apparently dies in battle. In the *Oedipus* of Euripides (of which a few lines survive), the servants of Laius boast that they blinded Oedipus. "We pushed the son of Polybus to the ground," they say; "we destroyed his eyes and blinded him" (Euripides, *Oedipus*, fr. 541). At the end of Sophocles' *Oedipus Tyrannus*, he is led into the palace, whereas the playwright had earlier indicated (1446–1454) that Oedipus was to be thrust out of the city to wander and die on Mt. Cithaeron, where he had been exposed as a baby. In the *Phoenissae* of Euripides (produced about a decade before the *Oedipus at Colonus*), Oedipus is still in the palace at the time of the expedition of the Seven against Thebes and Jocasta is still living. After his sons have killed each other and Jocasta has killed herself over their corpses, he emerges for the first time and is sent into exile by Creon. At the end of the play, he leaves Thebes accompanied by Antigone and foretells that he will come to Colonus: in this respect, the version of Euripides harmonizes with that of Sophocles. In his final speech in the *Phoenissae*, Oedipus looks back over his tragic life (1758–1763):

### Oedipus the Hero

Oedipus is basically an archetypal Greek hero whose legend is consistent with the criteria given at the beginning of this chapter or with Propp's formulation (see Chapter 1, pp. 13–14). The *Odyssey* version of the story focuses on the kingship of Oedipus—he kills his father, king of Thebes; succeeds him; and inherits his wife. After she commits suicide, he continues to rule and dies, as a king often does, in battle (as may be implied in the *Iliad's* reference to his death). Kingship, rather than incest, is the focus of Oedipus' myth (as opposed to that of Epicasta/Jocasta) in its early stages. Sophocles seems to have brought the theme of incest into the foreground, and in so doing to have taken the myth beyond the traditional ending of the hero's quest, that is, the winning of a bride. And from Sophocles' great tragedy have descended the psychoanalytical theories in Chapter 1.<sup>7</sup>

Other than kingship and family relations, the myth also focuses on the hero's wisdom and his effect on society. Gustave Moreau (see image on p. 416) commented in preparing his painting that Oedipus was "a man of mature age wrestling with the enigma of life," and for Moreau this was the principal focus of the myth, not parricide and incest. For Lévi-Strauss and the structuralists, the myth mediates between extremes in family relationships that would be intolerable otherwise. Others have adopted the structuralist approach of including all variants of a myth in their context. Jan Bremmer, for example, accepts the Freudian notion of father–son rivalry and sees the Greek myth as a "warning to the younger generation" to respect their fathers, whom they will succeed. Modern fascination with the Freudian interpretation—powerful and satisfying as it may be—should not obscure the origins of the myth in the role of kingship in preclassical Greek society, nor should we ignore the fact that the myth as we have it is made up of many elements from different Greek (and non-Greek) societies.

O citizens of my glorious homeland, look! Here am I, Oedipus, I, who knew the hard riddles; I, once the greatest of men. I alone ended the violence of the murderous Sphinx. Now I, the same man, I am being driven out of my land, a pitiful figure, deprived of my rights. Yet why bewail these things and weep in vain? A mortal must endure what the gods compel him to suffer.

## The Seven against Thebes

### The Preliminaries to the Expedition

In his speech cursing Polynices in the *Oedipus at Colonus*, Oedipus refers to an earlier curse that he had laid upon his sons, Eteocles and Polynices (1375). According to early epics, now lost, they had disobeyed Oedipus by using a golden cup and a silver table belonging to Laius in serving a meal to him while he was shut up in the palace, and he cursed them. Later, they served him a less honorable portion of meat than was his due as a king, and he cursed them again. The curses were that they should divide the kingdom of Thebes, that there should “always be war and battle between them,” and that they should kill each other.<sup>8</sup> Thus the curse uttered in the *Oedipus at Colonus* is the third one.

The curses were fulfilled after Oedipus’ death or (in the version of the *Phoenissae* of Euripides) while he was still alive. Eteocles and Polynices quarreled over the kingship at Thebes. They agreed that each should rule in alternate years, while the other went into exile. Eteocles ruled for the first year, while Polynices went to Argos, taking with him the necklace and robe of Harmonia. At Argos Polynices and another exile, Tydeus of Arcadia, married the daughters of the king, Adrastus, who promised to restore them to their lands and decided to attack Thebes first. This war and its consequences are the subject of the saga of the Seven against Thebes, which is the title of one of the tragedies of Aeschylus.

Several other dramas deal with the saga, including two with the title *Phoenician Women*, one by Euripides and the other by the Roman author Seneca. The consequences of the war are the subject of *The Suppliant Women* by Euripides and of *Antigone* by Sophocles. The saga is most fully narrated by the Roman poet Statius, whose epic, *Thebaid*, written in about A.D. 90, was widely read in medieval and Renaissance Europe.

**Capaneus.** Campanian red-figure vase, ca. 350 B.C. On the left, Capaneus, holding the torch in his left hand and an axe (grasped horizontally) in his right hand, climbs the ladder. The thunderbolt that will destroy him is painted in the top left panel; to the right of it are two defenders. In the right upper panel is an old man with a scepter. Below him is a winged woman, similar to the Vanth of Etruscan mythology (see the next illustration). At the bottom, a fourhorse chariot approaches from the right. (*The J. Paul Getty Museum, Villa Collection, Malibu, California*)



The Argive army had seven leaders: besides **Adrastus**, **Polynices**, and **Tydeus**, there were **Capaneus**, **Hippomedon**, **Parthenopaeus**, and **Amphiaräus**. Amphiaräus, who had the gift of prophecy, knew that except for Adrastus all seven would be killed and therefore opposed the expedition. But Polynices bribed Amphiaräus' wife, **Eriphyle**, with the necklace of Harmonia, to persuade her husband to change his mind. As he set out, he ordered his sons to avenge his death on their mother and themselves to make an expedition against Thebes when that of the Seven had failed.

### Incidents on the Journey from Argos to Thebes

Before the army reached Thebes, two episodes intervened. At Nemea (not far from the Isthmus of Corinth), they were led to a spring of water by Hypsipyle, nurse of Opheltes, the infant son of the local king, Lycurgus. (See p. 611 for the earlier life of Hypsipyle and her part in the saga of Jason.) She left the baby lying on the ground while she showed the way, and he was killed by a serpent. In Euripides' tragedy *Hypsipyle*, Eurydice, wife of Lycurgus, tries to kill Hypsipyle but is prevented by Amphiaräus. He entrusts Hypsipyle to her sons by Jason, Thoas and Euneos, who were searching for their mother and arrived at Nemea just then, and they take her back to Lemnos. The Seven killed the serpent and in honor of the dead child celebrated the athletic contests that became the **Nemean Games**. Amphiaräus changed his name from Opheltes (Snake Child) to Archemorus (Beginner of Death), as an omen of what was yet to come.

In the second episode Tydeus was sent to Thebes as an ambassador to demand the abdication of Eteocles in accordance with his agreement with Polynices. While at Thebes, Tydeus took part in an athletic contest and by winning humiliated the Thebans, who ambushed him as he returned to the army. Tydeus killed all fifty of his attackers, except for one man who took the news to Thebes.

### The Failure of the Attack on Thebes

When the army reached Thebes, each leader attacked one of the city's seven gates. The central part of Aeschylus' tragedy *Seven against Thebes*, consists of matched speeches in which the herald describes each of the Seven and is answered by Eteocles, who stations a Theban hero at each gate of the city. The herald's speeches give a vivid idea of the qualities of each Argive hero (selections from Aeschylus, *Seven against Thebes* 375–685):<sup>9</sup>

Tydeus raging . . . shouts out with midday cries like a dragon. . . . Upon his shield he has this proud sign embossed, the heaven blazing beneath the stars. The bright full moon, the oldest of the stars, the eye of night, shines brightly in the middle of the shield. . . .

Capaneus . . . is another giant, greater than the one already named. . . . He threatens to sack the city, whether the god is willing or not. . . . His device is a naked man carrying fire, and the torch with which his hand is equipped blazes, and in golden letters he says, "I will burn the city."

Hippomedon with a war-cry stands before the gates of Athena. . . . It was no mean craftsman who placed this work upon his shield, Typhon, belching fiery 10



smoke through his mouth, and the encircling hollow of the shield is covered with wreathed serpents. . . .

[Parthenopaeus the Arcadian] swears . . . that he will violently sack the city of Cadmeia. . . . Upon his bronze shield he wields the flesh-eating Sphinx, the reproach of the city. . . .

The sixth I would say is the most virtuous man, the prophet best in might, strong Amphiaraüs. . . . Upon his shield was no sign, for he did not wish to seem, but to be, the best. . . . Against him I advise setting wise and virtuous defenders, for terrible are those whom the gods revere.

Finally, the herald describes Polynices, whose threats against his brother are the most terrible of all. Upon his shield is a double device, a woman leading an armed man:

She says she is Justice, as the inscription says: "I will bring this man back, and he shall possess his father's city and go about its houses." (646–648)

In these descriptions, Aeschylus has given an impressive picture of the heroic stature of the Seven, whose individual characters are delineated through the devices on their shields. Eteocles refuses to be intimidated and arms himself for battle, denying that Justice is on Polynices' side. He knows that he must kill his brother, and he knows that in so doing he will be the instrument fulfilling the curse of Oedipus. When the Chorus asks him if he wishes to kill his own brother, he replies, "When the gods give evil, you cannot escape their gift."

These were the final words of Eteocles before the Seven attacked the city, and they express the inevitability of the curse on the sons of Oedipus. The failure of the Seven was foretold by the Theban prophet Tiresias, who prophesied that if one of the Spartoi sacrificed himself, the city would have atoned fully for the blood-guilt incurred by the killing of Ares' sacred serpent and so be saved. Here is part of the prophecy of Tiresias, as given by Euripides (*Phoenissae* 931–941):

This man [i.e., Menoeceus] must be killed at the lair of the earthborn serpent, the guardian of Dirce's fountain, and he must pay the earth with his blood for the water drawn by Cadmus. This is the result of the ancient anger of Ares, who will avenge the death of the earthborn serpent. If you [i.e., Creon and the Thebans] do this, you will have Ares as your ally. If the earth takes your fruit for hers, and for her blood the blood of mortals, she will favor you—she who once put forth the gold-helmeted crop of Sown Men [*Spartoi*]. Of their descendants, one must die, one who is descended from the serpent.

Menoceus, son of Creon and a descendant of the Spartoi, willingly died for the city: "Dying for the city," says the messenger in Euripides' play (*Phoenissae* 1090–1092), "he plunged the black-bound sword through his throat to save this land, upon the top of the city-walls," and so he fell into the serpent's lair. In the ensuing fight, only Capaneus succeeded in scaling the wall. As he reached the top, he boasted that not even Zeus could keep him out, and for his blasphemy "Zeus," says Sophocles (*Antigone* 131–137), "hurled him with brandished fire as he stood upon the parapet eager to raise the victory cry. Down he fell to the hard earth, hurled through the air, as he breathed out rage and madness in his frenzied assault."

Eteocles and Polynices killed each other in single combat, which Statius describes at great length in Book 11 of his epic, *Thebaid*. Even after death their enmity continued. Statius imagines Antigone, after the battle, trying to burn the corpse of Polynices on the very place where Eteocles had been cremated. She cries out in horror as the flames split in two with divided tongues, symbols of the brothers' eternal hatred.

Of the other heroes, Hippomedon, Parthenopaeus, and Tydeus fell in battle. (Tydeus, indeed, could have been made immortal by Athena, whose favorite he was, but she revoked her gift when she saw him eating the brains of the man who had fatally wounded him.)

According to Euripides (in his tragedy *The Suppliant Women*), Adrastus and the mothers of the Seven went to Eleusis (in Attica) as suppliants. Helped by Aethra, mother of Theseus, they persuaded Theseus to attack Thebes and obtain an honorable burial for the dead Argives. Theseus returned victorious with the corpses of the heroes (other than Polynices, Amphiaräus, and Adrastus himself), and conducted their funeral rites. Capaneus was granted a separate pyre, and his widow, Evadne, threw herself into its flames.

## Amphiaräus

Only Amphiaräus and Adrastus escaped; Adrastus was saved by the speed of his divine horse Arion and returned to Argos; Amphiaräus was swallowed up in the earth, with his chariot and driver, as he fled along the banks of the river Ismenus, one of the rivers of Thebes. The scene is vividly described by Statius (*Thebaid* 7. 816–820):

The earth parted with a deep, steep-sided chasm, and the stars above and the dead below were both struck with fear. The huge abyss swallowed Amphiaräus and enveloped the horses as they began to cross. He did not relax his hold on his arms or the reins: just as he was, he drove the chariot straight into Tartarus.

Amphiaräus became an important hero, and chthonic cults (i.e., cults whose ritual was directed toward the earth and the Underworld) were established in his honor in several places. He was worshiped at the place beside the river Ismenus where he was said to have descended into the earth. His most famous cult was at Oropus (a city in northeastern Attica near the border with Boeotia), where an elaborate shrine, the Amphiaräum, was developed in the fifth century B.C. (see p. 265). He exemplifies the hero who is associated with the place (or places) where his life was said to have ended. Like Oedipus at Colonus, he experienced a mysterious death and made the place where he disappeared holy.

## Antigone

The deaths of Eteocles and Polynices posed difficult religious and political dilemmas, which are presented in Sophocles' tragedy *Antigone*. The four children of Oedipus and Jocasta, as noted earlier, were Antigone, Ismene, Eteocles, and Polynices. Creon, Antigone's uncle, became king of Thebes again on the death of Eteocles. He gave orders that Polynices was not to be buried, on the grounds that he was a traitor who had attacked his own city. To leave the dead unburied



**Death of Eteocles and Polynices.** This Etruscan funerary ash urn (third to second century B.C.) depicts the heroes as they have fallen in mortal combat. Two supporters on each side attend the heroes. Between them flies a winged Vanth, a female demon associated with death. She holds a torch in her right hand.  
(© DeA Picture Library/Art Resource, NY)

was an offense against the gods, for it was the religious duty of the relatives of the dead to give them a pious burial. Antigone, as the sister of both Eteocles and Polynices, owed such a burial to both brothers, even though she would be breaking Creon's edict by burying Polynices. Alone (for Ismene refused to join in her defiance), she gave him a symbolic burial by throwing three handfuls of dust over his corpse. For this Creon condemned her to be buried alive. Antigone expresses her defiance of Creon in words of unforgettable power (Sophocles, *Antigone* 441–455):

CREON: Do you admit that you did this or deny it?

ANTIGONE: I admit it and I do not deny it.

CREON: Did you know that this was forbidden by my decree?

ANTIGONE: I knew it for it was clear to all.

CREON: And yet you dared to break these laws?

ANTIGONE: Yes, for it was not Zeus who gave me this decree, nor did Justice, the companion of the gods below, define such laws for human beings. Nor did I think that your decrees were so strong that you, a mortal man, could overrule the unwritten and unshaken laws of the gods.

Antigone was right. Creon's order defied the law of the gods, and he was soon punished. His son **Haemon** attempted to save Antigone (to whom he was engaged to be married) and, finding she had hanged herself in her tomb, killed himself with his sword. Creon's wife, **Eurydice**, killed herself when she heard the news of her son's death. Warned by Tiresias, Creon himself relented too late.

The *Antigone* of Sophocles, like his *Oedipus Tyrannus*, shows how human beings cannot ignore the demands of the gods. Antigone is a heroine who is willing to





**Antigone Is Brought before Creon.** Lucanian (South Italian) *nestoris* by the Dolon painter, ca. 380 B.C. The *nestoris* was a type of large vase developed in southern Italy early in the fourth century B.C.—wide in the middle and narrow at the foot and neck, with two pairs of handles, one horizontal and the other vertical, extending from the center to the neck; the base of one of each pair can be seen to the right of this scene. The scene shows the moment when Antigone is brought before Creon, who is seated on a stool to the left, wearing a tiara and an oriental headdress. Two guards escort her, one of whom addresses Creon. Antigone has drawn up her cloak over her head and she keeps her right hand inside the cloak, while with her left she gestures as if about to speak. This painting illustrates a theatrical performance, rather than literally interpreting Sophocles' text. (© The Trustees of the British Museum)

incur a lonely death rather than dishonor the gods by obeying the king's command.<sup>10</sup>

Sophocles' dramatization of eternal political, philosophical, and moral issues is enhanced by his illuminating portrayal of Antigone herself. Some perceive Antigone as a romantic heroine but have difficulty providing evidence from the text. Nowhere in the play does she even mention Haemon, her betrothed. After Antigone has been brought as a prisoner to face Creon, she chastises Ismene for her unwillingness to participate in her deed and scornfully rejects Ismene's offer to die with her. Ismene asks Creon (569) if he will kill the woman who is to be the bride of his son. He replies that he will do so because he does not want Haemon to marry an evil wife.

At this, Ismene exclaims (571): "O dearest

Haemon, how your father dishonors you!" Those who want desperately some direct expression by Antigone of her feelings toward Haemon would assign this line to Antigone, in defiance of our manuscript tradition.

Sophocles deliberately focuses solely on Haemon's love for Antigone. After the confrontation between Haemon and Creon, Haemon leaves in a rage and the Chorus sings about the invincible power of love (Eros and Aphrodite), which has stirred up this bitter quarrel between father and son, and it is a love that has been inspired by the desire aroused by the soft cheeks and beautiful eyes of his betrothed. When the messenger relates the terrifying scene in the tomb, where Antigone by her suicide has cheated Creon of the possibility of saving her and redeeming himself, once again, it is Haemon's love for Antigone that becomes a focal point.

After the tomb is opened, Creon beholds Antigone, hanging by the neck and Haemon by her side with his arms about her waist, bewailing the death of his bride, her murder by his father, and his marriage lost. Creon calls out to his son to come out of the tomb. Haemon does not answer but only glares at him angrily and spits in his face. Then he draws his sword and makes for his father, who avoids the thrust. Furious with himself, Haemon drives his sword into his side. While still alive, he clasps his beloved and stains her white cheek with red blood. There they lie, corpse embracing corpse, his marriage rites, consummated in the realm of Hades.

One will never know how Antigone really feels about marriage to the son of Creon, a man whom she must hate, even before their conflict over the burial of Polynices, because of what she, together with her father, Oedipus, has already suffered at his hands. (One suspects that Creon, as the brother of Jocasta, had encouraged this marriage to affirm his new power in Thebes by strengthening his ties to the family of the Labdacids.) At any rate, for Antigone, Hades is her bridegroom, and her tomb, her bridal chamber. She will not be denied her pious martyrdom, inspired by her passionate devotion to the supremacy of divine over human law and ultimately her love for her brother.

In the first part of the play, Antigone appears as a heroic personality, relentless in her defiance and fierce, just like her father, as the chorus observes (471–472). As

she is led away, however, and faces, all alone, the horrifying reality of the consequences of her actions—to be buried alive—she reveals her inner conflict and remorse. She laments the destiny of her family and that of her father, his incestuous marriage with her ill-fated mother. Her brother Polynices by his death has destroyed her life. To this family she now goes, accursed, unmarried, childless, confident that she has won their loving acceptance in the afterlife. No regret is expressed, however, for the loss of Haemon.

As she is about to be entombed, a distraught Antigone presents a desperate defense of her actions and asks anguished and disturbing questions about justice and the gods and the price she has to pay (905–928):

O Polynices, to those who are wise, I did right to honor you. If I had children die, of whom I was the mother, or a husband, rotting, unburied, never would I have undertaken this heavy task in defiance of the state. In deference to what law do I say this? If my husband had died, I could have taken another, and borne a child by another man, if I had lost the first, but since my mother and my father are hidden in the realm of Hades, never could another brother live for me. This is the nature of the law, by which I honored you above all, but Creon thought that I dared to commit a terrible crime, my beloved brother. . . . What justice of the gods have I violated? Why must I still look to the gods for help, wretched as I am? Whom can I call upon to be my ally? Although I acted piously, I stand convicted of impiety. If this seems right to the gods, I should forgive them for my suffering because I have indeed done wrong. But if the others are the ones who have done wrong, may they suffer no worse evils than they inflict unjustly upon me. 10

There is no compelling evidence for denying the authenticity of the preceding lines (endlessly disputed), in which Antigone's ultimate rationale is the fact that she could never have another brother.<sup>11</sup> Yet, they are rejected because of the interpretative sensibilities of some critics who will not allow their Antigone to resort to such an argument. But many, especially today, see in her words the complexity of her emotions: her psyche, revealed by the insight of Sophocles, the master of characterization. Her motives are complex, those of a grand, spiritual idealist and a disturbed and frantic human being.

Like Sophocles, Euripides wrote dramas on the Theban saga. Two of them, the *Oedipus* and the *Antigone*, are lost except for about 30 lines of each, but enough is known of them for us to learn that Euripides, writing some time after the production of the two plays of the same name by Sophocles, changed the legend. In the *Oedipus*, the servants of Laius boasted of having blinded Oedipus in the confrontation with Laius on the road (see p. 424). In the *Antigone*, Euripides invented (or transmitted) quite a different legend from Sophocles. Antigone and Argia, the widow of Polynices, placed the corpse of Polynices on Eteocles' pyre. When they were caught, Argia fled, but Antigone was taken to Creon who gave her to Haemon (who was betrothed to her and had already made her pregnant) to be executed. Haemon ignored his father's orders and instead gave Antigone into the keeping of some shepherds but told Creon that he had obeyed his order to kill her. Antigone gave birth to a son, Maeon, who years later came to Thebes and was recognized by Creon, who now realized Haemon's disobedience and, despite the intercession of Heracles, ordered the execution of the lovers. They frustrated him, however, by committing suicide. Some scholars conjecture that

Dionysus acts as the *deus ex machina*. Even from this conjectural reconstruction of the plot of Euripides' tragedy, it is clear that Euripides shared Sophocles' focus on Haemon's love, but that in extending the time between Antigone's "crime" and her death, he chose to dissipate the extraordinary power of Sophocles' presentation of the heroine.

Finally, in Euripides' (extant) *Phoenissae*, Oedipus is still in the palace at the time of the attack of the Seven, and Jocasta is still living. At the end of the play, Antigone defies Creon's order and promises that she will herself bury Polynices and kill Haemon, if Creon forces her to marry him. Creon weakens in the face of her defiance and sends her into exile with Oedipus.

## The Epigoni, Sons of the Seven against Thebes

Amphiaraüs had ordered his sons to attack Thebes and to punish their mother, Eriphyle, for her treachery in accepting the necklace of Harmonia from Polynices as a bribe. Alcmaeon, one of his sons, carried out these commands ten years later. He and the sons of the Seven (they are known as the **Epigoni**, "the later generation") made a successful expedition against Thebes and destroyed the city, which the Thebans had abandoned on the advice of Tiresias. At this point, saga touches on history, for the war of the Epigoni took place, it was said, not long before the Trojan War. In the catalogue of ships in the *Iliad*, which is certainly historical, only Hypothebae (Lower Thebes) is mentioned, implying that the ancient town and its citadel had been abandoned.

## Alcmaeon, Eriphyle, and the Necklace of Harmonia

Alcmaeon, encouraged by an oracle of Apollo, avenged his father by killing Eriphyle. The Furies pursued him as a matricide until he found temporary shelter in Arcadia, where he married the daughter of King Phegeus, giving her the necklace of Harmonia. But the land was soon afflicted with famine, the result of the pollution caused by the presence of the matricide Alcmaeon. Obedient to another oracle, he searched for a land on which the sun had not shone when he killed his mother. In western Greece, he found land at the mouth of the river Acheloüs recently formed by the river's silt. Settling here, he was purified of his guilt by the river-god, whose daughter Callirhoë he married. But he soon was killed by the sons of Phegeus for the crime of stealing the necklace of Harmonia in order to give it to Callirhoë. The necklace eventually was dedicated by the sons of Callirhoë and Alcmaeon at Delphi. Alcmaeon's sons became the founders of Acarnania, a district of western Greece.

## Tiresias

A recurring figure in the Theban saga is the blind prophet Tiresias. Descended from one of the Spartoi, he was the son of a nymph, Chariclo, a follower of Athena, and a Theban nobleman, Eueres. He appears in the *Bacchae* of Euripides as a companion of Cadmus in the worship of Dionysus (see pp. 306–308). Pindar (*Nemean Odes* 1. 60–69) describes him as "the outstanding prophet of Zeus" and tells how Amphytrion summoned him to interpret the miracle of the strangling of the snakes by the infant Heracles (we translate this passage on p. 556).

On this occasion, Tiresias foretold the labors of Heracles and his part in the defeat of the giants by the Olympians (see p. 86). Tiresias, then, was distinguished for his longevity; he lived for seven generations, says Hesiod, and he continued to have the gift of prophecy after his death, for in the Underworld, where the souls of the dead are insubstantial and futile, he alone retained his full mental faculties. Accordingly, Homer makes him Odysseus' informant when he consults with the dead, and he foretells the end of Odysseus' wanderings and the manner of his death.

There are different stories about Tiresias' blindness, an affliction shared by many prophets and poets in Greek literature. Ovid tells the story in full (*Metamorphoses* 3. 318–338):

They say that Jupiter once had driven away his serious worries with nectar and was joking with Juno, saying, "You women have more pleasure than men, I am sure." She disagreed, and they decided to ask the experienced Tiresias for his opinion, since he had known the act of love both as man and as woman. For once he had struck with his staff the bodies of two large serpents copulating in the green forest, and he miraculously passed seven autumn seasons turned from man into woman. In the eighth, he saw the same serpents and said, "If striking you has the power to change the striker to the other sex, then I will strike you again now." He struck the serpents, and his former body returned with his native physique. So, being made the judge of the lighthearted quarrel, he agreed with Jupiter. Juno, they say, was more angry than was just and condemned the arbiter [Tiresias] to eternal blindness. But the all-powerful father [Jupiter] granted him in return for the loss of his sight knowledge of the future. 10

The sight of two large snakes entwined in the act of copulation is mysterious and impressive, and a person who violates the snakes can readily be thought to have offended against a divine power. The idea of the violation of the divine is explicit in the second legend of the blinding of Tiresias, which is similar in this respect to the legend of Actaeon (see pp. 225–227), also a Theban hero. In this version (narrated by the third-century B.C. Alexandrian poet Callimachus), Tiresias came upon Athena and Chariclo as they were bathing in the waters of the fountain Hippocrene, on the slopes of Mt. Helicon. Athena caused him to lose his sight, a punishment for having seen what mortal eyes should not have seen, but gave him the power of prophecy. Callimachus (*Hymn* 5. 121–30) has her speak this to Chariclo:

Do not lament, my companion. For your sake I shall give him many other honors. I will make him a prophet, to be honored in song by future generations, a far greater prophet than any other. He will have knowledge of birds, those that are of good omen as they fly, and those that are ill-omened. He will give many oracles to the Boeotians and to Cadmus, and, last of all, to the family of Labdacus. I will give him, too, a great staff, to guide his feet where he must go, and I will give him a limit to his life after many generations. And he alone when he dies will walk among the dead having intelligence, and he will be honored by the great Gatherer of the People [i.e., Hades].

In the story of Oedipus, Tiresias revealed the truth before Oedipus or the Thebans were ready to understand it (Sophocles, *Oedipus Tyrannus* 350–367):



TIRESIAS: I bid you obey your own decree, and on this day speak neither to these men here nor to me, for you are the unholy pollution on this land.  
 OEDIPUS: Tell me again, that I may better learn.  
 TIRESIAS: I say that you are the murderer of Laius. Unwittingly you live most shamefully with those who are dearest to you, and you do not see how far gone you are in evil.

Oedipus still cannot believe Tiresias and goads him into telling him the truth even more terribly (412–419):

TIRESIAS: These are my words, since you have reproached me with being blind: you see, and you do not see the evil in which you are, nor where you live, nor with whom you dwell. Do you know from whom you are sprung? You do not know that you are hateful to your family below and above upon the earth, and that the double curse from your mother and your father will track you down and drive you from this land, now seeing clear, but then in darkness.

The words of Tiresias powerfully express the horror of Oedipus' crimes. Through the images of seeing and blindness, they bring before us the inevitability of the justice of the gods.

Tiresias, in Sophocles' *Antigone*, also warned Creon of the disastrous mistakes he was making, only to be understood too late. Finally, before the attack of the Epigoni, Tiresias advised the Thebans to abandon the city and migrate to found the city of Hestiaea. He never reached the new city; on the way, he drank from the spring called Telphusa and died on the spot.

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## Primary Sources

### Sources in the Chapter

|             |                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                       |
|-------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Aeschylus   | <i>Seven against Thebes</i> 375–685                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                   |
| Callimachus | <i>On the Bath of Pallas</i> (Hymn 5) 121–130                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                         |
| Euripides   | <i>Fragments</i> , edited by C. Collard & M. Cropp, 2 vols. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 2008 (Loeb Classical Library, 504, 506). Fragments of the lost plays of Euripides with English translation and informative introductions to each play. A valuable resource for all Greek sagas.<br><i>Phoenissae</i> ( <i>The Phoenician Women</i> ) 639–675; 931–941; 1758–1763 |
| Ovid        | <i>Metamorphoses</i> 2.846–3.2; 3.318–338                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                             |
| Sophocles   | <i>Antigone</i> 441–455; 905–928<br><i>Oedipus at Colonus</i> (selections)<br><i>Oedipus Tyrannus</i> (selections)                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                    |
| Statius     | <i>Thebaid</i> 7.816–820                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                                              |

### Additional Sources

|             |                                                                                                                                                                                             |
|-------------|---------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Apollodorus | <i>Library</i> 3.5.4–3.7.7: The legend of Thebes from Cadmus and Harmonia to Alcmaeon. For intricate details about the family and legends of Tydeus and Diomedes, read Apollod. 1.8.4–1.8.6 |
| Euripides   | <i>Suppliant Women</i>                                                                                                                                                                      |
| Seneca      | <i>Oedipus</i><br><i>The Phoenician Women</i>                                                                                                                                               |

## Notes

1. One of Laius' retainers escaped: in Sophocles' play, he is the very servant who originally failed to expose Oedipus, and his story brings about the final discovery of Oedipus' identity.
2. There are several variants of the riddle and its answer. The shortest (Apollodorus 3.53–54) is given here.

3. Cf. Lowell Edmunds, *Oedipus: The Ancient Legend and Its Later Analogues* (Baltimore, MD: Johns Hopkins University Press, 1985), a survey of the many versions of the myth. Two modern novels are of merit: *Oedipus on the Road* (1990), originally in French by Henry Bauchau, recounting the journey of Oedipus, blind and bleeding, from Thebes, with his daughter Antigone and a shepherd-bandit named Clius, through an imaginative geographical and spiritual landscape; and *Emmeline* (1980) by Judith Rossner, a powerful retelling of the Oedipus legend, set in the eastern United States in the mid-nineteenth century.
4. In the intervening four years, Athens had surrendered to Sparta and her allies at the end of the Peloponnesian War; the “long walls” between the city and its port had been pulled down. The democracy had been replaced by an oligarchy led by a committee of thirty, itself soon replaced by the restored democracy.
5. The transformation of the Erinyes (Furies) into Eumenides (Kindly Ones) is the climactic theme of Aeschylus’ *Oresteia* (see p. 443); Aeschylus brings the goddesses to Athens where they take up their new home.
6. In lines 1284–1345 of his speech, Polynices names the Seven against Thebes. We translate a similar passage from Aeschylus’ *Seven against Thebes* on pp. 426–427. Another catalogue is given by Euripides in the *Phoenissae* (1090–1199), where a messenger reports the failure of the attack on Thebes.
7. For a psychoanalytic interpretation, a good place to begin is with *Oedipus: Myth and Complex, A Review of Psychoanalytic Theory*, by Patrick Mullahy (see the Select Bibliography for this chapter). Mullahy discusses Sigmund Freud, Alfred Adler, C. G. Jung, Otto Rank, Karen Horney, Eric Fromm, and Harry Stack Sullivan. Of related interest is a study of the use of myth (with emphasis on psychoanalytic interpretation) in the works of William Butler Yeats, Ezra Pound, T. S. Eliot, and W. H. Auden: Lillian Feder, *Ancient Myth and Modern Poetry* (Princeton, NJ: Princeton University Press, 1971).
8. The legends contained in the lost epics (with the titles of *Oedipodea* and *Thebais*) are discussed by G. A. Huxley, *Greek Epic Poetry* (Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press, 1969), chap. 3.
9. The herald’s description of Eteocles (son of Iphis), whom Aeschylus names as the third hero in place of Adrastus, is omitted. For other catalogues of the Seven in Euripides and Sophocles, see note 6 in this chapter.
10. Antigone, as the symbol of individual conscience against the unjust laws of the state, has inspired many literary and musical works. See George Steiner, *Antigones* (Oxford: Oxford University Press, 1984).
11. Aristotle (*Rhetoric* 3.16.9) quotes lines from this passage, and so he must have known our text. That Antigone’s sentiments are not unique is shown by a story told by Herodotus (3.119) about Intaphernes’ wife, who makes the same argument as Antigone: she chooses to save the life of her brother on the grounds that she could never have another. The insightful Karl Reinhardt (*Sophocles*, translated from the German by Hazel and David Harvey. New York: Barnes & Noble, 1979) deserves the last word in this controversy (p. 84): “Just as Antigone follows divine law, and her own nature, so too she follows the *nomos* [law] of love for her brother. For Sophocles the one embraces the other.”

## The Mycenaean Saga

Where will the might of madness [*ate*] rest and end?

—AESCHYLUS, *Choephoroi*, 1075–1076



**THE LEGENDS OF MYCENAE** are particularly concerned with the House of Atreus and the greatest of its princes, Agamemnon, leader of the Achaeans against Troy. We consider the Trojan War later; in the present chapter, we discuss the fortunes of the house as they developed in Greece itself.

### Tantalus and Pelops

The ancestor of the family of Atreus was Pelops, son of Tantalus, who came from Asia Minor as a suitor for the hand of **Hippodamia**, daughter of **Oenomaüs**, king of Pisa, whose territory included Olympia. This fact accounts for the importance of Pelops in the religious cults at Olympia. From the end of the Mycenaean Age, Pisa and Olympia were for most of the time controlled by the Peloponnesian city of Elis.

In the time of Tantalus and Pelops, there was easy intercourse between gods and mortals, and in some way Tantalus abused the privilege of eating with the gods. In the best-known version of the myth, he invited the gods to dine with him and cut up his son Pelops, boiled the parts in a cauldron, and served them at the feast. Pindar is reluctant to believe the story, but he told it nevertheless (Pindar, *Olympian Ode* 1. 47–58):

One of the envious neighbors secretly told the tale that they cut your limbs up with a knife and [put them] into the water boiling over the fire, and at the second course of the meat at the tables they divided you and ate. I cannot say that any of the blessed gods was gluttonous—I stand aside. . . . But if the guardians of Olympus honored a mortal man, that man was this Tantalus. Yet he could not digest great fortune, and in his fullness he brought on himself great madness. Thus